

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN CÔTE D'IVOIRE

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

In Côte d'Ivoire the great destructive force is not one project but a commodity, and the lever that can reach it runs through the world's chocolate. The country is by far the world's largest producer of **cocoa**, and cocoa is the leading cause of its deforestation: it has lost the great majority of its natural forests in half a century, more than two million hectares cleared for cocoa in just the last two decades — endangered trees, elephants, and chimpanzees vanishing with the forest, and cocoa planted illegally deep inside the classified forests and national parks that were meant to be protected. At current rates, the forest cover could be all but entirely gone within a decade. Much of this destruction is driven by poor smallholder and migrant farmers seeking fertile ground; the state's response has sometimes meant evicting thousands of them, raising real human-rights concerns of its own; and the great chocolate companies' promises have too often gone unkept. A harm that flows out through the world's chocolate can be pressed back through it.

Because the destruction flows out through a commodity sold to a watching world, the levers that reach it run through the supply chain, and they are real. The **traders and chocolate companies** that buy Ivorian cocoa have made **zero-deforestation commitments** they can be held to. **New import rules barring deforestation-linked cocoa from wealthy markets** are a powerful, growing lever on the whole chain. **Satellite monitoring, supply-chain mapping, and certification** can expose deforestation and trace it to its buyers; protest, petition, and lawful advocacy have their place. And the **forest law, the classified forests, and the national parks** carry legal protection the invasion breaches. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. Much of the deforestation is done by poor farmers who clear forest because virgin soil grows the best cocoa and low prices push them to expand — so the forest cannot be saved by punishing the poor, and the state's enforcement, which has sometimes meant evicting thousands from protected forests, raises real human-rights concerns of its own, in a country still carrying the scars of civil conflict and sensitive disputes over land and belonging. The chocolate companies' promises have too often gone unkept. So the honest path is to defend the forest without abandoning the farmers — pairing the supply-chain and forest-law levers with deforestation-free livelihoods, and holding both the forest and the people who live from it. And though the cocoa frontier defines the fight, a community facing any other project — a mine, a dam, a port — has the ordinary domestic tools too: the environmental assessment, the courts, and the democratic and community channels. Aim for what these levers can genuinely deliver — deforestation exposed and traced, buyers held to their commitments and the import rules, the frontier slowed, the forest and the farmers both defended — not a single triumphant stop.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot save the forest by punishing the poor farmers who clear it, and there is no single project to stop. What you can do is press the harm back through the supply chain that carries it to the world: hold the traders and chocolate companies to their zero-deforestation commitments and the new import rules, expose and trace the clearing through satellite monitoring and certification, invoke the forest law and the parks — and pair it all with deforestation-free livelihoods, defending both the forest and the farmers who live from it.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Côte d'Ivoire is unusual: the harm is a commodity, the fight is a supply-chain and justice fight, and the obstacle is bound up with poverty, not simple villainy. That is the first honest truth — much of the clearing is done by poor farmers, and enforcement that only evicts them raises human-rights concerns and cannot save the forest. So aim at the winnable — deforestation exposed and traced, buyers and import rules pressed, the frontier slowed — while pairing every lever with alternative livelihoods, so the forest is defended without abandoning the people who live from it.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

The harm runs through a supply chain that reaches the world, so the decisions that matter are spread across it. The **traders and chocolate companies** who buy the cocoa answer to their own zero-deforestation commitments and to the import rules. The **wealthy-market regulators** who bar deforestation-linked cocoa hold a growing lever. The **certifiers and monitoring bodies** trace the deforestation. The **Ivorian forest authorities, the classified forests, and the parks** hold the domestic law. And the **farmers and forest communities** are both the drivers and the key to the solution. Map where in the chain the leverage lies before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

Deforestation moves as the cocoa frontier advances into forest, and the cocoa then flows through cooperatives, traders, and companies to the world's markets. You enter where the chain can be gripped: the buyers' commitments, the import rules at the wealthy markets, the monitoring that traces the clearing, the forest law at home. And you enter, above all, at the livelihood — the point where alternative income can stop a farmer from clearing the next hectare.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the cocoa: which cooperatives, traders, and companies buy from the deforestation frontier, and what commitments and import rules bind them. Follow the forest: which classified forests and parks the cocoa invades, and what the law protects. Follow the livelihood: what pushes the farmers to clear, and what alternatives could hold them. The leverage lies in the buyers' commitments, the import rules, the monitoring, the forest law, and the livelihoods.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

The watchers here are largely in the supply chain: the wealthy-market regulators enforcing the import rules, the certifiers and satellite-monitoring bodies, the traders and companies bound by their commitments, and the Ivorian forest authorities. These are the institutions a case is built to engage — holding each to its commitments, its rules, and the forest law.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Ivorian effort easily reverses the deforestation, and honesty requires saying so — the drivers are poverty and a global commodity. But the supply chain, the import rules, the monitoring, and the forest law are real. The single most decisive move is **tracing the deforestation to its buyers and pressing them through their commitments and the import rules**, because a commodity sold to regulated, watching markets can be pressed back through them, and because the buyers and regulators respond to exposed, traced harm.

The import rules are the growing lever; the buyers' commitments the handle; the monitoring the evidence; the forest law the domestic ground. And every lever must be paired with livelihoods — the only way to stop the frontier without punishing the poor. The realistic prize is deforestation exposed and traced, the frontier slowed, and the forest and farmers both defended.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the forest cleared for cocoa, the parks and classified forests invaded. **Where does the cocoa go?** — which cooperatives, traders, and companies buy from the frontier. **What binds the buyers?** — their zero-deforestation commitments and the import rules. **What protects the forest?** — the forest law, the classified forests, the parks. **What drives the clearing, and what could hold it?** — the poverty and the alternative livelihoods. Pick the frontier where the cocoa can be traced to a bound buyer, and where livelihoods can hold the farmers.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers. **Layer one: the harm and the trace** — the deforestation documented by satellite, and the cocoa traced through the supply chain to its buyers. **Layer two: the commitment and the rule** — the buyers' zero-deforestation commitments, the import rules barring deforestation-linked cocoa, the forest law and the parks the clearing breaches. **Layer three: the livelihood and the justice** — what drives the farmers, what alternatives exist, and the discipline of defending the forest without abandoning them or endorsing unjust evictions. A case built on satellite monitoring, supply-chain tracing, the buyers' commitments, and the import rules is one the chain and the regulators must answer.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm-and-trace record**: the satellite deforestation data, the supply-chain mapping tracing cocoa to its buyers, the invasion of classified forests and parks. Gather the **commitment-and-rule record**: the traders' and companies' zero-deforestation commitments, the wealthy-market import rules, the forest law. Gather the **livelihood record**: what drives the clearing, and the deforestation-free alternatives that could hold the farmers. Gather the **justice record**: the human-rights concerns of eviction, so the case defends the forest without punishing the poor. Much of the supply-chain data is genuinely obtainable through certifiers, monitors, and regulators.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE COALITION

The coalition here spans the chain and the forest. Build it from the **forest and farming communities**, both drivers and key to the solution; the **certifiers, satellite-monitoring bodies, and supply-chain researchers** who trace the harm; the **wealthy-market campaigners and regulators** who enforce the import rules; and the **traders and companies** who can be pressed on their commitments. Above all, build with the farmers around deforestation-free livelihoods, so the coalition defends the forest without pitting it against the people who live from it. The shared cause is a forest saved and a farmer sustained.

STEP 4: SUPPLY-CHAIN, IMPORT-RULE & FOREST-LAW LEVERS — PRESSING THE HARM BACK

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real and growing, but the drivers are poverty, and every lever must be paired with livelihoods.

The Buyers and Their Commitments

The **traders and chocolate companies** that buy Ivorian cocoa have made **zero-deforestation commitments** they can be held to. Trace the deforestation to a specific buyer and press it on its own promise — a reputational and, increasingly, legal lever.

The Import Rules and the Monitoring

New import rules barring deforestation-linked cocoa from wealthy markets are a powerful, growing lever on the whole chain, and **satellite monitoring, supply-chain mapping, and certification** are the evidence that exposes deforestation and traces it to its buyers. Together they turn the world's demand into a check on the clearing.

The Forest Law and the Livelihoods

The **forest law, the classified forests, and the national parks** carry the domestic legal protection the invasion breaches, and **deforestation-free livelihoods** are the indispensable complement — the only way to stop the frontier without punishing the poor. Pursued together — the buyers, the import rules and monitoring, and the forest law with livelihoods — these levers press the harm back through the chain while defending both the forest and the farmers.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For the traders and companies:** here is deforestation traced to your cocoa, against your own zero-deforestation commitment. **For the wealthy-market regulators:** here is deforestation-linked cocoa your import rules should bar. **For the certifiers and monitors:** here is the clearing to expose and trace. **For the Ivorian forest authorities:** here is a classified forest or park invaded, against the law. **For the farmers and the world:** here is a forest that can be saved with alternative livelihoods, not by eviction. **The golden rule:** press the harm back through the supply chain, and pair every lever with livelihoods, so the forest is defended without abandoning or punishing the poor.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media matters, because the harm is a commodity the world consumes. Frame the story around **the forest and the chocolate:** the world's chocolate driving the loss of Côte d'Ivoire's forests, and the supply-chain levers — and the livelihoods — that can turn it around. Carry it through the international outlets where consumers and regulators watch, the certification and monitoring networks, and the Ivorian press. A few cautions: keep it accurate and grounded in the traced evidence; never pit forest against farmer or endorse punishing the poor; and let the deforestation data, the buyers' commitments, and the import rules carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message factual, traced, and just toward the farmers.

8A — To a trader or chocolate company: present the deforestation traced to its cocoa and ask how it meets the company's zero-deforestation commitment.

8B — To a wealthy-market regulator: flag deforestation-linked cocoa the import rules should bar, with the traced evidence.

8C — To a certifier or monitoring body: request the satellite and supply-chain evidence and ask for the clearing to be exposed.

8D — To the Ivorian forest authority: document the invasion of a classified forest or park and press the forest law.

8E — On the livelihoods: set out the deforestation-free alternatives that could hold the farmers, and ask for their support.

8F — To the farming and forest community: set out the shared stake and the alternatives, and build the coalition without pitting forest against farmer.

8G — To a human-rights body: where eviction is the response, flag the concern and press for a just alternative.

8H — To the press: offer the forest-and-chocolate case, the traced evidence, and the livelihoods frame, and ask for coverage.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: pull the satellite deforestation data and trace the cocoa to its buyers; write the one-page supply-chain case (the harm, the trace, the commitment or import rule breached); identify the strongest buyer or regulator to press. **The fastest-moving levers:** the buyers' commitments, the import rules, and the monitoring. **Emergency coalition-building:** reach the monitoring and certification bodies and the wealthy-market campaigners first; they can act on the supply chain quickly. Throughout, pair every lever with livelihoods and never punish the poor.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is tilted by a global commodity, poverty-driven clearing, and unkept corporate promises. Recognise it, and lean on the levers the tilt cannot escape — the import rules the buyers cannot dodge, the monitoring that exposes the harm, the buyers' own commitments, the forest law. In a supply chain that reaches watching, regulated markets, exposure and tracing are powerful. Accept, honestly, that the promises have too often gone unkept, and that the only durable answer pairs the supply-chain levers with livelihoods that hold the frontier.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Distinguish the ordinary tilt from capture — cocoa laundered from protected forests into "clean" supply chains, officials shielding the trade, commitments made only for show. Where capture appears, respond through the **supply-chain and international channels:** the import rules, the monitoring and certification, the buyers' commitments, the traced evidence, the wealthy-market regulators. **On safety and justice:** Côte d'Ivoire still carries the scars of civil conflict and sensitive disputes over land and belonging, and enforcement has meant evicting the poor. So keep the work lawful and careful; never endorse punishing the poor or pitting forest against farmer; frame it around the forest and the livelihoods; and be mindful of the human-rights concerns that eviction raises. Justice toward the farmers is part of defending the forest.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel. The traced deforestation feeds the buyer pressure, the import-rule enforcement, and the forest-law claim at once; the coalition of communities, monitors, and campaigners organises alongside; the media carries the forest-and-chocolate frame throughout; and the livelihood work runs beneath it all. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document and trace the deforestation to its buyers; **months two to six**, press the buyers, the import rules, the monitors, and the forest law, and advance the livelihoods; **beyond**, hold the frontier with alternative income and sustained supply-chain pressure. The core discipline: trace the harm back through the chain, and pair every lever with livelihoods, defending both forest and farmer.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Côte d'Ivoire is an unusual ground, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim the deforestation can be reversed by a single stop, or that the forest can be saved by punishing the poor, or that a landmark victory exists — none of that is true, and the drivers are poverty and a global commodity. What it claims is narrower and real: that a harm which flows out through the world's chocolate can be pressed back through it — that the traders and companies answer to zero-deforestation commitments; that new import rules bar deforestation-linked cocoa from wealthy markets; that satellite monitoring and certification can expose and trace the clearing; that the forest law and the parks protect the ground; and that, above all, deforestation-free livelihoods can stop the frontier without abandoning the farmers. The levers are real and growing, the work supply-chain-and-justice work, and the prize is deforestation exposed and traced, the frontier slowed, and the forest and farmers both defended. For a country whose destructive commodity is sold to a watching world, that is not a lesser ambition — it is the responsible and effective one, holding both the forest and the people who live from it.